Unit -1

Sources of Medieval India



Learning Objectives

To acquaint ourselves with

- Sources of the study of medieval India
- Temples, mosques, tombs, palaces and forts as important sources
- Literary and inscriptional texts
- Accounts of Arab and Turkish travellers

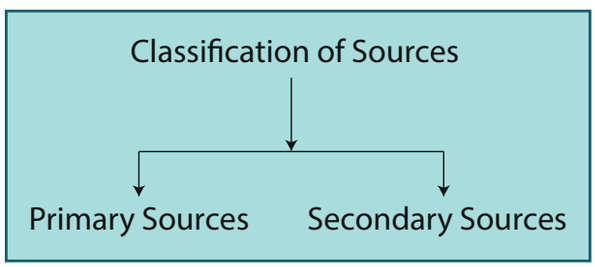
Introduction:

The periods from A.D. (CE) 700 to 1200 and from A.D. (CE) 1200 to 1700 are classified as Early Medieval and Later Medieval periods, respectively, in Indian history. Numerous and varied sources are fortunately available to the historians engaging in the study of Medieval India. Added to the information that can be gleaned from inscriptions, monuments and coins are the accounts left by Arab, Persian and Turkish chroniclers. These accounts are rich in detail and have given first-hand information on the life of kings, though they provide very little information on the life of the common people. The opinions of the courtiers and chroniclers are often one-sided, written in a hyperbolic language, exaggerating the king's achievements. Let us now explore the various sources available for the study of the history of Medieval India.

Do you know the famous words of Khafi Khan, a courtier of Emperor Aurangzeb? He says, 'It is the duty of an historian to be faithful, to have no hope of profit, no fear of injury, to show no partiality on one side, or animosity on the other, to know no difference between friend and stranger, and to write nothing but with sincerity.'

Sources

Sources are the supporting materials, documents or records in the form of evidence that help to reconstruct the past.



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